

Re-engineering behaviour

We all know by experience, and countless New Year's resolutions to attest to the fact, that changing one's habits is easier said than done. Habits are deeply ingrained memory blocks in our brain that are difficult to erase, change, or re-engineer. Habits, often as we know, can also be more than just a nuisance. Spitting on the roadside is more than just bad habit – for instance, it can come back to bite you in the form of sickness and disease-spreading germs that fester in exposed saliva. Similarly, noise pollution is another social evil that's practiced by millions of Indians on roads every day, despite the fact that this #1 cause of noise pollution increases heart rate and blood pressure, leading to hypertension and increased stress. Prolonged exposure to noise can lead to potentially fatal consequences.

Tackling the menace of "bad habits" among Indians with the help of behavioural science is Anand Damani, easily one of the most interesting people we've encountered. Along with his cousin, Mayur Tekchandaney, Anand works for consultancy firm Briefcase in which he uses science to change human behaviour – apply the knowledge of behavioural economics and cognitive neuroscience to change consumer, organisational and social behaviour. Amongst many social problems, excessive honking happens to be the first anti-social behaviour they're trying to tackle.

Honk, begone!

Angad's invention, a Behavioural Design intervention device makes the driver conscious of his/her honking. It makes the driver deliberate whether the honk is really required or not. The technology they've used to make drivers reduce their honking is a little red button placed on the dashboard of a car. When the horn is pressed, the button beeps and flashes, and basically annoys the driver. To turn it off, the driver has to press the red button. "We've called this little button Bleep," says Anand, "because we believe indis-



ANAND DAMANI

BIO: "I'm a partner in consultancy firm Briefcase in which I use science to change human and social behaviour. In addition I handle the business and strategy of our Branding practice. Have worked 13 years in sales, marketing and advertising in the past."

criminate honking is like an abuse and this device helps Bleep out that abuse. The patent includes several additional features like capturing honking and vehicle data, displaying it with the driver, making sure the driver knows he/she is in a silence zone, etc."

Anand explains that he enlisted the

services of Dhruv Chaudhry, an automobile engineer, who helped them create Bleep as a fully functional product. His team then tested it amongst people – office-goers, housewives, chauffeurs and measured their honks per km without and with Bleep over six months and 3,800 kms. Thanks to Bleep, he claims that his test candidates reduced their incessant or unwarranted honking by over 60 per cent.

Knowing fully well that Bleep won't be something that people will install voluntarily in their cars, Anand is trying different approaches to promote Bleep. "For it to become a reality," says Anand, "Bleep needs to be made mandatory in all vehicles because it's for the benefit of everyone in society. So we're not selling Bleep to individual customers. Rather we are approaching Govt. authorities to guide us with how to go about making it a reality. We're also in talks with the NY Taxi and Limousine Commission to see how it can be piloted in NY cabs as its drivers are known to honk unnecessarily and cause noise pollution."

Behaviour change is not easy, according to Anand. We know we should exercise but we don't. We know we should eat in moderation but we don't. So we are irrational beings and often we do things against our self interest. And conventional awareness based campaigns and education are ineffective at changing behaviour.

On a parting note, Anand leaves us to mull over the following: So we use Behavioural Design which is typically about creating small nudges that have a lasting measurable impact on behaviour. And there are so many applications of it for changing public behaviour in India and the world. From health to sanitation to education to employment to managing money better – the list of places where it can be applied for the betterment of society is endless. US and UK governments have begun using behavioural science for effective public behaviour changes and it's time for the Indian government to adopt such effective practices too."

HOW DO YOU USE TECHNOLOGY?

"We use technology in creating interventions to change behaviour. Our objective is to nudge people and make them act in a particular way. We do not use technology for its own sake. In certain cases of behaviour change, the technology is very simple or not even used. In other cases technology is critical to behaviour change. But as technology is becoming more embedded in our lives we will be using more and more of it to create behaviour change. Overall we use technology with respect to all senses – sight, sound, smell, taste and touch," says Anand.